

The AI PoC Evaluation Checklist

How to define success for an AI project before you sign. Seven checks that protect your budget, whoever builds the system.

- ☐ **1. Define the job in one sentence**
What exact task or decision does the AI perform, and for whom? If it takes a paragraph, the scope is not ready.
- ☐ **2. Build the golden dataset before any code**
20 to 30 real cases from your business, including the ugly edge cases, not just the easy wins. This is the test the system must pass.
- ☐ **3. You own the word "correct"**
Your team reviews and approves the expected answer for every case. The vendor builds, the golden dataset judges.
- ☐ **4. Put the pass bar in writing**
Agree upfront what passing means, for example 18 of 20 approved cases, and what happens if the bar is missed. A miss should be a cheap stop, not a renegotiation.
- ☐ **5. Demand honest evaluation reports**
Results on every case, failures included. A highlight reel of best answers is a demo, not an evaluation.
- ☐ **6. Gate the phases**
PoC, then MVP, then production. Each gate is a go/no-go decision on measured results, not on impressions.
- ☐ **7. Check the data reality first**
Confirm the data the AI needs exists, is accessible, and can be traced to its source. In my experience, failed AI projects die in the data layer far more often than in the AI layer.

Asaf Lavi, founder and owner of AL Solutions. AI architecture, products and design: agentic systems, RAG and knowledge assistants, data copilots, document AI, AWS-native delivery.
Questions about a project you are scoping? Message me on LinkedIn.